

Summary - Workbook 1

Whole-passage summaries: keep the point, essential details, and important relationships.

How to use this workbook

Read each text, identify its central idea, and then choose the option that keeps only the essential information. The correct summary should be accurate, concise, and complete enough to represent the whole passage.

Before you start

- Find the main idea first. Then decide which 1-2 supporting points are essential to understanding it.
- Delete examples mentally. If the passage gives several examples of one idea, the summary usually
- names the idea rather than listing every example.
- Do not add advice. A summary reports what the text says; it does not tell the reader what should happen.

Text 1 - Library Laptop Reservations

A college library changed its laptop checkout system after students complained that devices were often unavailable during busy weeks. Students can now reserve a laptop online up to two days in advance, while a smaller number of devices remain available for walk-in checkout. During the first six weeks, fewer students arrived expecting a laptop that was unavailable. Staff are continuing to track no-show reservations before deciding whether to adjust the system.

1. Which statement best summarizes the text?

A. The library introduced advance laptop reservations while keeping some walk-in devices and is monitoring

whether the new system works well. B. Students can reserve laptops online up to two days in advance. C. Libraries should require all students to reserve technology before visiting. D. No-show reservations are the main reason laptops are unavailable.

2. Which choice is too narrow to be an effective summary?

A. The library is testing a mixed reservation and walk-in system to reduce device availability problems. B. Students may reserve a laptop online up to two days in advance. C. The new system appears to reduce some availability confusion, but staff are still reviewing its effects. D. The library changed checkout procedures and is collecting more evidence before making further changes.

Text 2 - Cooling a School Courtyard

A school planted eight shade trees around a concrete courtyard that became very hot in the afternoon. Two years later, the trees were large enough to shade several seating areas. Temperature readings showed that shaded surfaces were cooler than uncovered concrete, and students used the courtyard more often during lunch. Because the trees still cover only part of the space, the school is considering additional shade structures.

3. Which statement best summarizes the text?

A. After planting trees, a school courtyard gained cooler shaded areas and more student use, but the school may

still add other shade. B. Eight trees were planted around a concrete courtyard two years ago. C. Trees are the only effective way to cool

outdoor school spaces. D. Students prefer eating lunch outside whenever trees are present.

4. Which information is least necessary in a concise summary?

- A. The school planted trees to create shade. B. Shaded surfaces became cooler. C. Exactly eight trees were planted. D. The school is considering more shade because coverage is incomplete.

Text 3 - A Different Route Home

When a bridge near Elena's apartment closed for repairs, her usual bus route was redirected for three weeks. The temporary route took ten minutes longer but stopped beside a small market she had never visited. Elena began buying fruit there on her way home and learned the names of several shop owners. When the bridge reopened, she returned to her faster bus but sometimes got off one stop early to visit the market.

5. Which statement best summarizes the story?

- A. A temporary change to Elena's bus route led her to discover a market she continued visiting even after her old route returned. B. Elena's normal bus route was ten minutes faster than the temporary route. C. Markets near bus stops are more successful than other markets. D. Bridge repairs usually help people discover new places.

6. Which choice adds an idea that the story does not support?

- A. The route change was inconvenient but also created an unexpected opportunity. B. Elena continued visiting the market after the bridge reopened. C. The bridge closure was planned so local businesses could attract more customers. D. Elena's habits changed because of a place she discovered during the detour.

Text 4 - Testing Refillable Cleaning Stations

A university placed refill stations for soap and cleaning products in two residence halls. Students could reuse approved containers instead of buying a new bottle each time. During the pilot, purchases of single-use bottles fell, but staff spent additional time checking that returned containers were clean and correctly labeled. The university is comparing waste reduction with staffing costs before deciding whether to expand the stations.

7. Which statement best summarizes the text?

A. A university refill-station pilot reduced single-use bottles but added staff work, so the university is weighing both effects before expanding it. B. Students are required to reuse containers for all cleaning products. C. The main purpose of residence halls is to reduce plastic waste. D. Staff found it impossible to keep refill containers clean.

8. Why is choice A a stronger summary than a statement that says only "The pilot reduced single-use bottles"?

A. Because a good summary should include every number in the passage. B. Because the passage also presents a staffing cost that affects the decision. C. Because summaries should always be longer than main ideas. D. Because the passage is mainly about residence hall rules.

Answer key and reasoning

1. **A.** A keeps the problem, the new system, and the ongoing evaluation. B is one detail; C and D add unsupported ideas.
2. **B.** B gives only one rule and leaves out the purpose and evaluation of the change.
3. **A.** A keeps the action, results, and remaining limitation. B is detail-heavy but incomplete; C and D overstate.
4. **C.** The exact number is not needed to understand the central meaning of the passage.
5. **A.** A keeps the temporary disruption, discovery, and lasting change. B is only one detail; C and D generalize beyond the story.
6. **C.** The story never says the closure was intended to help businesses.
7. **A.** A preserves both the benefit and the tradeoff, which are central to the decision described.
8. **B.** The tradeoff is essential to the passage's overall meaning and final decision.

Mistake check

- Too many details? Try replacing lists of examples with the larger category they illustrate.
- Missed a tradeoff? If the passage presents benefits and limits, the summary often needs both.
- Added a recommendation? Delete any should, must, best, or worst claim that comes from you rather than the author.